THE CALDO DEEP DIVE, OCTOBER 2026

Can you make money on Sleeper touchdown picks?

A plain-language walkthrough of what we tested, what we found, and what to do on game day.

13%	0 of 107	−$427	10%
what Sleeper keeps on each touchdown pick	props with a profitable side on Oct 17	expected season for your 3/5/8 plan	chance that plan ends a season ahead

The short version

- **Sleeper copies the market's odds and adds a markup.** Its payouts match the prediction market Kalshi almost exactly, minus about 13% on every touchdown pick. On Oct 17, not one of 107 touchdown props had a side that would make money over time.
- **Parlays multiply the markup.** Each extra leg takes another cut, so an 8-leg slip gives up more than half of your $20 on average, even though it pays more when it hits.
- **A better model doesn't fix it.** We tested nine models on three seasons. The best ones were about as accurate as the market, not better, so they can't overcome Sleeper's markup.
- **Kalshi charges about a third as much for the same pick.** That's cheaper, not free. Without an edge, every venue still loses roughly its fee.
- **The only clearly profitable things were Sleeper's promos:** rare discounted "free pick" lines and the deposit match.

How to read this guide

Each step builds on the one before. If you only have two minutes, read the box at the end of each step and the weekly playbook near the end. The full technical report, with every source, is *reports/Sleeper Picks profitability deep dive.md* in the Caldo repo.

STEP 1

How Sleeper prices a pick

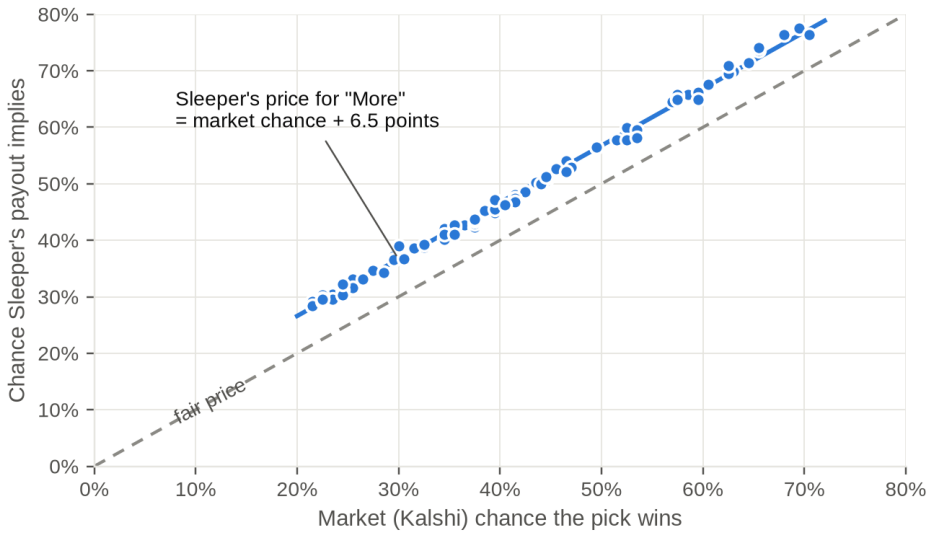
Every Sleeper pick shows a **multiplier**, such as 1.78x. Turn that into a percentage by dividing 1 by it: 1 ÷ 1.78 = 56%. That's how often the pick has to hit for you to break even. Now do the same for the other side of the same prop.

Worked example

A typical line pays **1.78x on More and 1.78x on Less**. Each side needs to hit 56% of the time to break even, so the two sides together add up to **112%**, not 100%.

That extra 12% is Sleeper's cut. On touchdown props it's bigger, about **14% in total** across both sides, which works out to roughly 12–13% kept from each touchdown pick you make.

To see where Sleeper gets its numbers, we lined up Sleeper's touchdown prices on Oct 17 with Kalshi, a prediction market where people trade on things like "Player X: 1+ touchdowns." A Kalshi price of 40¢ means traders, betting real money, put the chance at about 40%.



Each dot is one Sleeper "More" pick on Oct 17, 2026 (107 touchdown props). The dashed line is a fair price. Every dot sits above it by about 6.5 points: Sleeper prices a 30% player as if he were 37%.

The dots sit on a near-perfect straight line (correlation 0.998). Sleeper isn't setting its own odds; it's taking the market's odds and shifting them in its favor. On "More" picks it adds about 6.5 points of probability. On "Less" picks it adds about 3.4 points plus 6%.

What this means for you

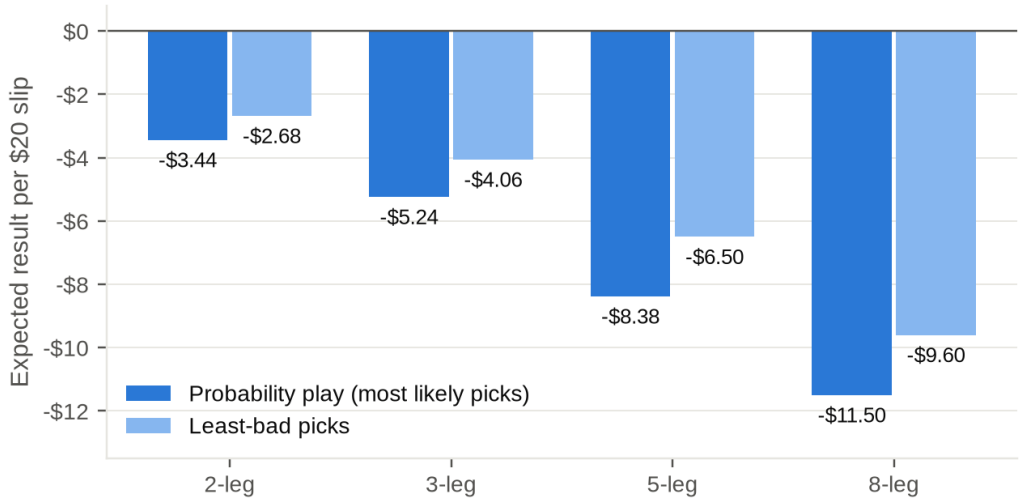
Using Kalshi's price as the fair chance, **every one of the 107 props lost money on both sides.** "More" picks lost about 16¢ per dollar on average and "Less" picks about 11¢. The best single pick on the whole board still lost 6¢ per dollar. Notice that about 84–98% of Sleeper players take "More", which is the side with the bigger markup.

STEP 2

Why parlays make it worse

A slip pays the product of its legs' multipliers. That means the markup on each leg is multiplied too. If each leg gives up about 12%, two legs keep 0.88 × 0.88 = 77% of fair value, three legs keep 68%, and eight legs keep only about 35%.

The "probability play" (stacking the most likely picks) does win more often. But Sleeper lowers the multiplier in step with how likely a pick is, so winning more often doesn't mean making more. We priced this week's board at Kalshi's fair odds to get the average result of a $20 slip:



Expected result of a $20 Sleeper slip, Week 6 board, using Kalshi's prices as the fair chance. "Least-bad picks" are the sides with the smallest markup, whatever their chance of hitting.

Slip	How often it wins	What it pays	Average result per $20
3-leg probability play	33%	2.21x	−$5.24
5-leg probability play	14%	4.06x	−$8.38
8-leg probability play	3.6%	11.72x	−$11.50
2-leg, least-bad picks	49%	1.76x	−$2.68

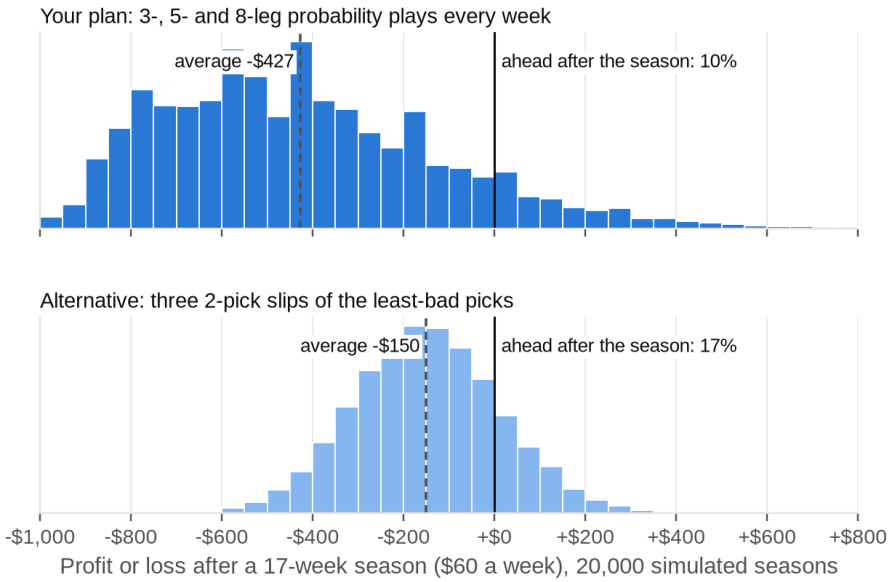
What this means for you

Every extra leg costs you. Going from three 5- and 8-leg slips to short 2-leg slips is the single biggest change you can make, much bigger than picking players better.

STEP 3

What a whole season looks like

One weekend tells you almost nothing, so we simulated 20,000 full 17-week seasons of your plan ($20 each on a 3-, 5- and 8-leg slip every weekend, $1,020 total) and of a cheaper alternative.



Each bar shows how often a season ended at that profit or loss. The solid line is break-even; the dashed line is the average season.

Weekly plan ($60 a week)	Average season	Bad season (1 in 20)	Good season (1 in 20)	Ends ahead
Your 3/5/8 probability play	−$427	−$843	+$128	10%
Three 2-pick slips, least-bad picks	−$151	−$404	+$110	17%

Real results bounce around a lot. When we replayed your plan on 2026 Weeks 2–5, favorites got hot: 80% of legs hit when about 59% was expected. The 3-leg won three weeks out of four and the slips finished about **+$10 on $240**, while the market's expectation for those same slips was **−$96**. In Week 5 alone, 12 of 16 legs hit and all three slips still lost.

What this means for you

A good month on this plan is mostly luck, and it's easy to mistake luck for a system that works. That's why the tool now has a bet log: it shows what the market expected next to what actually happened.

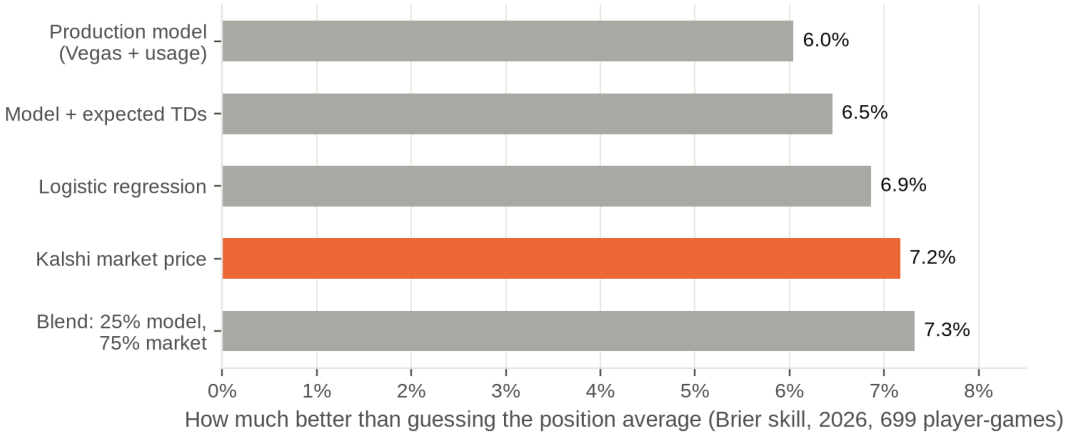
STEP 4

Can a better model beat it?

We built and tested nine ways of predicting touchdowns, from "every running back gets the same chance" to machine learning. Each week was predicted using only games played before it, the same way you'd use it for real. The tests covered about 6,000 player-games from 2024 through Week 6 of 2026.

Model	What it looks at	Verdict
Position average	Same chance for every RB, WR or TE	The baseline to beat
Player's own TD rate	How often he has scored lately	Barely beats the baseline; badly overconfident
Expected-TD rate	Quality of his chances: goal-line carries, end-zone targets	Better, still overconfident
Main model (in the tool)	Vegas team total, his share of carries and targets	Solid and well calibrated
Main model + expected TDs	Same, half credit from expected TDs	Slightly better; now the default
Logistic regression	22 inputs, statistical fit	Best in 2026 only
Gradient boosting	Flexible machine learning	Overfits; worst of the learned models

To compare models fairly we used the **Brier score**: the average squared gap between the predicted chance and what happened. Lower is better. The chart below turns it into "how much better than guessing the position average." The orange bar is Kalshi's price an hour before kickoff, on the same 699 player-games.



Accuracy compared with guessing the position average, 2026 Weeks 1–6. The market (orange) beat every model on its own, though the gaps are small and not statistically certain over six weeks.

Two things stand out. The ceiling is low: even the best models' top-10 picks each week scored only about 57–59% of the time. And the market was at least as accurate as every model. The best result came from mostly trusting the market (75%) with a little model mixed in, which is now the tool's default.

The "value pick" trap

When the model disagreed with the market and flagged a pick as "value", it was usually a long-shot "More". Those are the picks the market rates as the worst on the board, and the ones Sleeper marks up the most. In our replay, none of the model's value strategies made money beyond luck. To win on Sleeper, a model would have to beat the market by more than Sleeper's 6.5-point markup. None of ours beat the market at all.

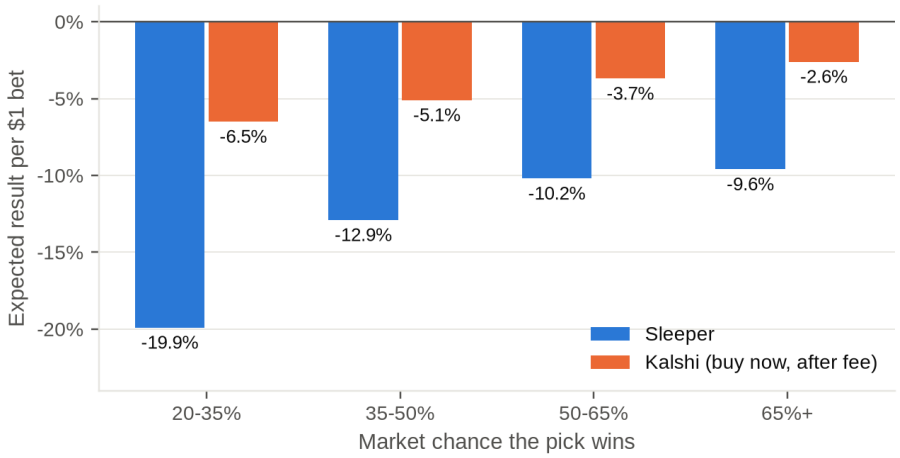
STEP 5

Sleeper vs prediction markets

Prediction markets like Kalshi and Polymarket don't set the odds against you. Bettors trade with each other, and the venue takes a fee. On Oct 17 we priced the same 220 touchdown picks on all three:

Venue	Average payout per $1 if it wins	Average result per $1	Had the best price
Sleeper	1.95x	−13.1%	0% of picks
Kalshi (buying now, after fee)	2.17x	−4.5%	66% of picks
Polymarket (buying now, after fee)	1.91x	−19.2%*	34% of picks

* Polymarket is cheapest on "More" picks for popular players, where lots of money is waiting to trade. But most of its player markets are thin (only 6 of 220 had a tight price), which makes "Less" picks very expensive. Its few prices that looked like bargains were orders worth about $1.



Same pick, two venues: expected result per $1 by how likely the pick is (Oct 17, 2026). Kalshi was cheaper at every level.

For parlays, Kalshi offers "combos". It prices those on request, so we estimated them from the fair price plus a 0–3% markup per leg and the fee:

Your weekly card	Sleeper	Kalshi combos (estimated)
3-leg probability play	pays 2.2x, average −$5.15	pays 2.6–2.8x, average −$0.88 to −$2.47
5-leg probability play	pays 3.9x, average −$8.05	pays 5.3–6.1x, average −$1.12 to −$3.69
8-leg probability play	pays 10.5x, average −$11.47	pays 18–23x, average −$1.26 to −$5.20
Whole season (17 weeks)	about −$419	about −$55 to −$193

What this means for you

Moving the same picks to Kalshi cuts your cost by roughly two-thirds. **It's still not profitable:** without an edge over the market, you lose about the size of the fee. The combo numbers are estimates until you see a real quote. Kalshi is also blocked or contested in some states, including Michigan, Nevada, Washington and Ohio as of mid-October 2026.

We couldn't test Novig or ProphetX, because they don't publish prices we could read.

STEP 6

What actually has positive value

Sleeper's promo lines. A few times a week Sleeper posts discounted or boosted picks. On Oct 17 its promo feed had 8 across all sports, 2 of them NFL:

- **A slashed line:** a quarterback's passing yards More **0.5** at 1.78x, when his normal line was 227.5. A starting QB clears half a yard about 98% of the time, so this pick is worth roughly **+74 cents per dollar**. Paired with the least-bad regular pick in a 2-pick slip, the slip is still worth about +60%.
- **A boost:** receptions More 6.5 raised from 2.03x to 2.20x. Against the fair chance (about 44%), that's still a small loss (about −4%). A boost isn't automatically a good bet.

Promos are rare and come with entry limits, and boosted winnings are paid as bonus credit that expires in 30 days. Check the app each weekend: the tool's *--sleeper* option lists the public ones, but promos tied to your account don't show up there.

The deposit match. Sleeper matches a first deposit 100% up to $100 (code PLAY). You have to use the money in contests within 30 days before you can withdraw it. Clearing it with 2-pick least-bad slips keeps most of the bonus. It's a one-time gift, not a strategy.

A lead worth watching, not betting yet. Kalshi's "2+ touchdowns" markets paid out more often than their prices said this season: 43 hits where 28.8 were expected among players priced at 5–30%. That could be a real pattern (touchdowns tend to come in bunches) or six weeks of noise in a high-scoring season. Sleeper doesn't sell 2+ TD picks anyway. The right move is to track it on paper for the rest of the season.

How sure are we?

Finding	How sure we are
Sleeper keeps about 12–13% per touchdown pick	Established (two snapshots, three weeks apart)
Longer slips lose more; your plan expects −$427 a season	Established
Kalshi is cheaper than Sleeper for the same pick	Established for one live snapshot
Kalshi combos would cut the season cost to $55–$193	Estimate: combo prices weren't observed
No model beats the market	Consistent direction; small sample
Promo lines are positive value	Real, but rare and limited
Kalshi underprices 2+ TD games	Possible; not established

STEP 7

Rules to know before you play

Where Sleeper Picks is legal. As of August 2026, paid Player Picks run in 30 states plus DC. They are **not** available in Arizona, Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, Hawaii, Idaho, Iowa, Kentucky, Louisiana, Maine, Maryland, Michigan, Mississippi, Montana, Nevada, New Jersey, New York, Ohio, Pennsylvania or Washington. You must be 18 (19 in Alabama and Nebraska, 21 in Massachusetts and Virginia). Vermont allows fantasy-point picks only, which rules out touchdown props. The geolocation check in the app is the final word.

Sleeper's Terms of Service. Sleeper's terms (updated Oct 6, 2026) ban pulling data from the app with bots or scripts, and let Sleeper restrict accounts and take back winnings from anyone who does. The tool's *--sleeper* option reads Sleeper's lines automatically, so it falls under that ban even though the data is public. **Typing the lines in yourself with *--lines* avoids the problem.** Sleeper can also change entry limits and multipliers on individual accounts.

Taxes. Win $600 or more in a year and Sleeper will ask for your Social Security number for tax reporting.

> **Keep it fun**
>
> Set a weekly limit you're comfortable losing and treat it as the cost of entertainment. If betting stops being fun, call or text 1-800-GAMBLER.

YOUR NEW ROUTINE

The weekly playbook

The goal is the same weekend fun for a lot less money, plus grabbing any real freebies when they show up.

1. **Check promos first.** Look in the app for discounted lines and boosts. A slashed line (like 0.5 passing yards) is the best pick you'll see all week. Pair it with your least-bad regular pick.
2. **Keep slips short.** Three 2-pick slips instead of 3/5/8. If you want one longer slip for fun, keep it to 3 legs.
3. **Pick the least-bad legs, not the most likely ones.** Prefer "Less" on players under about a 50% chance to score, and "More" only on strong favorites. Skip long-shot "More" picks and first-TD-scorer props.
4. **Enter Sleeper's lines by hand and compare with the market.** Type the multipliers into a lines file and run the tool with Kalshi. It shows how much each pick loses and the house edge on each slip.
5. **Consider the cheaper venue.** If Kalshi is legal where you live, the same picks cost about a third as much. It's still not free.
6. **Log every slip, then grade it.** Compare what you won with what the market expected, so a lucky month doesn't fool you.

The commands

```
python -m tdmodel week --lines my_lines.csv --kalshi --log bets.csv
python -m tdmodel grade --log bets.csv
```

my_lines.csv has one row per pick: player, market (anytime_td or pass_tds), line, side (more or less) and the Sleeper multiplier you see in the app. *lines_example.csv* in the repo shows the format.

What changed in the tool

- The default model now blends actual and expected touchdowns, the one upgrade that tested better.
- With *--kalshi*, each pick's odds are 75% market and 25% model, because the market was at least as accurate.
- Each pick shows what it would pay on Kalshi after fees, next to Sleeper's multiplier.
- Each slip shows the market-only view: its real chance of winning and the house edge.
- *--sleeper* lists promo lines (subject to the Terms of Service caveat in Step 7).
- New *--log* and *grade* commands track real results against expectations.

REFERENCE

Words used in this guide

Term	Meaning
Multiplier	What Sleeper pays per $1 if a pick wins. A slip pays the product of its picks' multipliers.
Break-even chance	1 divided by the multiplier: how often a pick must win to break even. 1.78x needs 56%.
Markup (overround)	How far both sides' break-even chances add up past 100%. That's the house's cut.
Expected value (EV)	The average result per bet if you made it many times. −13% means you lose 13¢ per $1 on average.
Least-bad pick	The side of a prop with the smallest expected loss, whether or not it's likely to hit.
Prediction market	A venue like Kalshi or Polymarket where bettors trade with each other and the venue takes a fee. A 40¢ price means about a 40% chance.
Combo	Kalshi's version of a parlay, priced on request.
Expected touchdowns (xTD)	How many TDs an average player would score with the same chances, based on where on the field his carries and targets happen.
Brier score	Average squared gap between predicted chance and what happened. Lower is better.
Calibrated	When a model says 30%, it happens about 30% of the time.
Walk-forward test	Predicting each week using only games before it, so the test can't peek at the answers.

Where everything lives

What	Where (Caldo repo, branch claude/sharp-wozniak-sj0tsk)
Full technical report with sources	reports/Sleeper Picks profitability deep dive.md
Research notes	research_notes/Sleeper Picks profitability deep dive/
Scripts that reproduce every number	research/ (see research/README.md)
The betting tool and its instructions	tdmodel/ and README.md

All prices are from Oct 17, 2026 (the Week 6 slate) unless noted. Prices change by the minute, so rerun the tool before you bet. Nothing here guarantees a result.